



Napoleon after his victory at the Battle of Jena in Saxony.

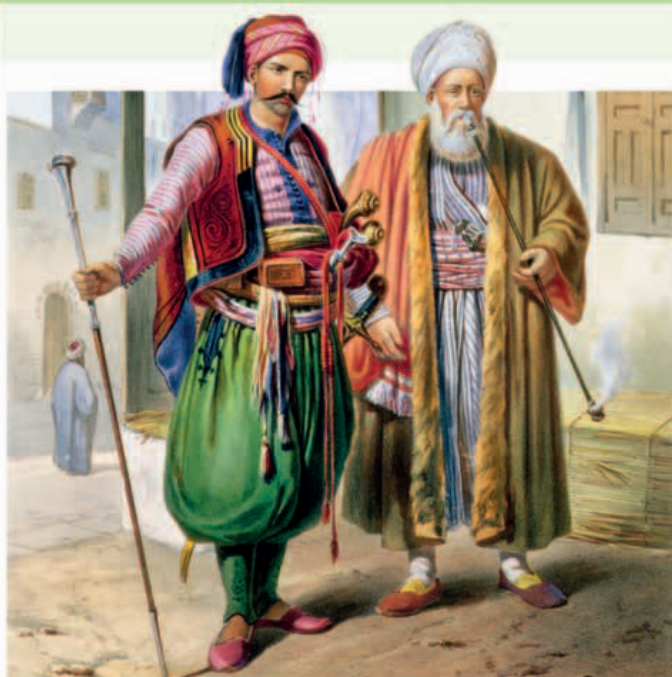
PRUSSIA SUFFERED A DEVASTATING defeat against France at the **Battle of Jena** on October 14. Fought in Jena and Auerstädt in Saxony (southeast Germany), 122,000 French troops and 114,000 Prussians met in combat. As a result, Frederick William III (1770–1840) decided that internal reform in Prussia was necessary in order to bolster the country's flagging fortunes. Among the numerous measures taken, **serfdom** was abolished. Although the transition later proved profitable for agriculture, it took years to implement the changes.

In addition to his other conquests, Napoleon wanted control of the **Holy Roman Empire**, which would expand his territory in Germany. Emperor Francis II (1768–1835) was in no position to challenge France and **abdicated**, officially ending the empire, of which France took possession.

In the Middle East, the Islamic holy pilgrimage site of **Mecca** was invaded by members of the Arabian **Saudi** dynasty who practiced a strict version of the religion known as **Wahhabi**. In 1805, they had captured **Medina**, which, like Mecca, was under the control of the Ottoman Empire. They also made incursions into the Arabian Peninsula, sacking the city of **Karbala**, in Iraq (also under Ottoman rule), and extending their influence south to **Yemen**, a cause for concern among Ottoman officials.

“YOU MAY **CHOOSE TO LOOK THE OTHER WAY** BUT YOU CAN NEVER SAY AGAIN THAT **YOU DID NOT KNOW.**”

William Wilberforce, to the English parliament prior to the vote on the Abolition Bill, 1789



Elite force

A Janissary, left, in Cairo. Initially the bodyguards of the sultan, the Janissaries became the elite troops of the Ottoman Empire army.

THE LONG BATTLE LED BY English abolitionist and politician **William Wilberforce** (1759–1833)—and the thousands of members of the British public who supported his campaign—finally came to fruition in 1807 as the bill to **abolish the slave trade** was passed with an overwhelming majority. The legislation, however, only ended the trade in Britain. It did not end the practice of slavery.

Russia, alongside Prussia, had reentered the hostilities against France with the **Battle of Eylau** (February 7–8) in eastern Prussia. The battle was inconclusive and resulted in a stalemate, with both sides losing more than 20,000 troops. After a decisive Russian defeat at the later **Battle of Friedland**, Russia signed one of

the **Treaties of Tilsit** on July 7, while Prussia signed the other on July 9. Under the terms of the treaties, France and Russia formed an alliance, while the territories of Austria and Prussia were significantly reduced.

In the Ottoman Empire, auxiliary troops called **Yamaks** erupted into a revolt over attempts to introduce European-style reforms to the military. They were soon joined by the elite **Janissary** soldiers. The unrest culminated in the assassination of Selim III (1761–1808).



Francisco Goya's painting *The Third of May* depicts the French troops executing Spanish insurgents involved in the Madrid uprising.

ALREADY IN CONTROL OF MOST of western and central Europe, Napoleon now turned toward the Iberian Peninsula. Enraged by the Portuguese refusal to back a French boycott against Britain, he sent troops into Portugal via northern Spain. The presence of French troops, as well as previous unpopular concessions to France, provoked the Spanish people to rise up, calling for the abdication of their monarch, **Charles IV**, in favor of his son, **Ferdinand VII** (1784–1833). Ferdinand took the throne, but it was to be very short-lived.

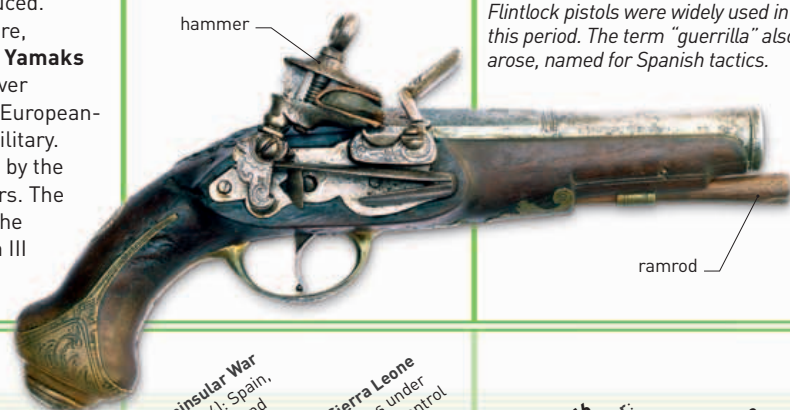
Lured to Bayonne, France, by Napoleon's offer to mediate, Ferdinand VII was forced to abdicate. As Charles VII had already abdicated, Napoleon was now able to declare his brother, Joseph Bonaparte (1768–1844), the new king of Spain, triggering the **Peninsular War**. When news of these events reached Spain's colonies, there were furious outbursts. In Santo Domingo, loyalists mounted the **War of Reconquest** (to 1809), driving out the occupying French troops and declaring the island once more under Spanish control.

LONG-STANDING ENEMIES, Spain and Britain now fought alongside each other as they united against France. British troops met early defeat at the **Battle of La Coruña**, northwest Spain, fighting French troops under Napoleon's direct command. Britain was subsequently victorious at the **Battle of Talavera** (July 27–28), southwest of Madrid, under the leadership of Arthur Wellesley (1769–1852), later known as the **Duke of Wellington**.

The Spaniards, while fighting the French, had also been establishing provincial bodies, called **juntas**, in order to organize their resistance. The central junta in Spain had also issued a decree declaring the American territories to be more than just colonies, but still a part of the monarchy. Across the Atlantic it was obvious that there was a crisis of **legitimacy** in Spanish rule—without a king, to whom did allegiance lie? While debates about this were underway, similar American juntas were set up, and it soon it became clear that not all the colonies would stay on the path of loyalty to the Crown.

Pistol from Peninsular War

Flintlock pistols were widely used in this period. The term “*guerrilla*” also arose, named for Spanish tactics.



French urge Ottomans to declare war on Russia; fighting lasts until 1812

August 6 Formal abolition of Holy Roman Empire

February 7–8 Napoleon defeats Russia at Battle of Eylau

March 25 Britain abolishes the slave trade in all its territories

British fail to take Buenos Aires during attempt to seize colonies of Spain, the ally of France

Peninsular War (to 1814): Spain, Portugal, and Britain against France

Sierra Leone comes under British control

January 16 Peninsular War: British defeated at La Coruña, Spain

February 8 Austria declares war on France

British take Cape Colony from the Dutch again to prevent French control

October 14 Napoleon defeats Prussians at twin of Jena and Auerstädt battles

Janissary revolt leads to deposition of Ottoman leader Selim III, replaced by Mustapha IV (1779–1808)

June 14 Russians defeated by France at Battle of Friedland

November Portuguese royal family flees to Brazil after France invades Portugal

June 6 Joseph (1768–1844), Napoleon's brother, is placed on the Spanish throne

September 17 Sweden cedes Finland to Russia under the Treaty of Hamina